



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Cathedral School of Saint Mary
School Website: <https://smcschoolaustin.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Cathedral School of Saint Mary (Austin, TX 78701) demonstrates a robust classical-Catholic orientation across curricular content, pedagogy, and community life. Public materials emphasize a historically grounded Catholic identity, a commitment to a classical curriculum, and a structured progression through the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and liberal arts, including Latin and great-books-influenced study. Evidence of liturgical life, communal worship, religious formation, and collaboration with families reinforces a coherent Classical Catholic model. While category-specific signals are overwhelmingly Classical (with one category showing only partial alignment), the aggregate impression is CLASSICAL.

Key strengths include: explicit Catholic formation and liturgical practices; a stated classical curriculum with grammar/logic/rhetoric foundations; emphasis on Great Books and the Great Conversation; a pedagogy that blends memorization and chant in early grades with Socratic/seminar-style inquiry in later years; and active partnership with families as co-educators. Notable elements that temper an otherwise uniform Classical stance include the more explicit articulation of formation and faith life over job-prep rhetoric in public-facing materials and a faculty narrative that, while aligned with virtue-formation, does not consistently foreground the “living curriculum” language seen in some classical-program descriptions (explained further in the category-by-category notes).

What would move the needle? If the school further foregrounded explicit language about the living curriculum and teacher-as-virtue-mentor role, and if it broadened public statements to consistently articulate the Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium/Quadrivium) with accompanying Great Books/readings commitments beyond the current Catholic-classical framing, it would push any remaining room toward a fully explicit CLASSICAL label across all six elements.

ABSTRACT

classification result: CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials emphasize a strong Catholic identity, liturgical life, and communal worship (weekly Mass, adoration, rosary, and monthly virtue emphasis; liturgical rhythm). This includes explicit statements about liturgy, eucharistic life, and sacred time within the school community.
- The school’s philosophy and mission frame education as formation within a Christ-centered, theological context, with goals centered on spiritual development in collaboration with families.
- The curriculum and program presentation explicitly connect Catholic formation with classical instruction, signaling a synthesis of theology with the liberal-arts-centered curriculum.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: theology, faith, liturgy, sacred, Mass, adoration, worship, virtue, Gospel, Christian formation, sacred tradition, Catholic identity, divine law, Christ-centered education, the Logos.

The “Six Essential Elements” rubric highlights transcendental realities, liturgical life, and theology as core positives; the CSSM materials map closely to these signals. The result shows an alignment with Positive Keywords for Element 1.

- Negative keywords: minimal presence of secular or relativistic framing; no explicit signals of “values-neutral” approaches. The Positive Keywords significantly outpace any Negative Signals.

Why this rating

- The catechetical and liturgical life, the explicit Catholic mission, and the theology-infused formation described in the materials land squarely in the Positive Keyword universe laid out in the Six Essential Elements document, supporting CLASSICAL.

Cited sources

- Liturgical life and Catholic identity in Spiritual Life, Mass/Adoration/rosary: public-facing materials.
- Mission/Philosophy/Goals emphasizing formation in collaboration with families and Gospel-centered aims: Our Purpose materials.
- Classical framework anchored in Christian formation and Great Books orientation: What is Classical Education? discussion in the curriculum overview.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school describes formation as the core aim: forming the whole child (spiritual, intellectual, social, physical) in collaboration with families; aims include worship, virtue, and a classical instructional program rather than mere job-prep. This aligns with “formation” over information and with the pursuit of wisdom/virtue.
- Goals articulate spiritual life (worship as a faith community) and academic life (classical instruction) with social formation in a Christ-centered environment.
- Mission and vision language connects wisdom, virtue, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty within a Catholic framework.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, character, human flourishing, moral imagination, sacred tradition, Christian formation, Logos. The site repeatedly articulates formation of the whole person as the goal, with explicit mention of classical instruction and virtue development.
- Negative keywords present: minimal presence of career-prep focus or job-market rhetoric; no explicit “workforce readiness” framing in core statements. The balance favors formation over utilitarian/tech-tracking language.

Why this rating

- The school emphasizes formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth/beauty within a Catholic framework, consistent with CLASSICAL.

Cited sources

- Our Purpose / Mission/Vision/Philosophy/Goals emphasizing formation and the classical instructional program.
- Spiritual formation and worship as part of purpose (formation of the whole child).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The public materials clearly present a classical curricular framework anchored in the grammar–logic–rhetoric progression and liberal arts orientation. Descriptions in the foundational materials explicitly

reference the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), along with Latin and Great Books oriented study.

- The program includes Religion, Grammar, Latin, Spanish, Literature, History, Nature Studies, Math, and Arts, with explicit reference to liberal-arts structure and total curriculum coherence.
- The school explicitly situates itself within a “great books” and “Great Conversation” tradition as part of the curriculum, indicating engagement with canonical texts and primary sources.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; quadrivium components like arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books, Great Conversation, interdisciplinary integration, history as a throughline, Latin, classical curriculum, formation through the liberal-arts framework.
- Negative keywords present: minimal to no signals of a purely modern, skills-based, or test-centric approach in the public-facing curriculum materials; the text leans away from “Lack of Great Books” or “Lack of seven liberal arts” signals.

Why this rating

- The explicit articulation of the Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, and integrated liberal-arts framing aligns with CLASSICAL.

Cited sources

- Public description of Classical Education including Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, and the aim of forming through liberal arts.
- Curriculum listing including Religion, Grammar, Latin, Spanish, Literature, History, Nature Studies, Math, Art, Music.
- Great Books/Great Conversation framing within the curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Lower grades show memory-rich practices (singing, chanting, memorization) that cultivate memory, delight, and recall, consistent with the Schöle (Scholé) emphasis in early-Greek and medieval pedagogy that values contemplative and restorative elements as part of education. The Kindergarten curriculum topic guide emphasizes singing, liturgical music, and memory work.
- Upper grades emphasize Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training, with explicit reference to logic and rhetoric in the pedagogy, aligning with classical practice where higher-level thinking is developed through dialectic and rhetoric. The classical progression description (grammar–logic–rhetoric) supports this as well.
- The site explicitly frames the school as practicing a classical model that structures learning by developmental stage (grammar stage through logic stage, with rhetoric in a later stage).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Scholé (restful, contemplative learning), singing/chanting in lower grades, memorization, Socratic discussions, seminars, debates, rhetoric, memory-building/recitation, development by stage.
- Negative keywords present: there is no explicit signaling of purely project-based, task-driven, or purely vocational pedagogy in the core statements; the pedagogical signals strongly favor contemplative, classic methods.

Why this rating

- The presence of contemplative/restful elements in early grades, combined with Socratic/seminar/rhetoric in higher grades, matches CLASSICAL pedagogy signals.

Cited sources

- Kindergarten singing/memory-focused approach.
- Socratic/seminar/debate emphasis and rhetoric training in upper grades via the classical model and curriculum framing.
- Public articulation of the classical pedagogical framework and stage-based learning.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The site communicates a formal faculty structure and a philosophy of growth in collaboration with families; the philosophy emphasizes collaboration with parents and formation of the whole child, suggesting teachers as moral exemplars and mentors. However, explicit public language calling the faculty “the living curriculum” or “the core of the school” is not consistently visible in the publicly accessible text. The presence of a long-running Catholic faculty tradition (Sisters of Holy Cross historically) and current lay faculty indicates a continuity of virtue-signaling and mentorship, but without explicit “living-curriculum” phrasing in the public materials.
- Public materials describe teachers as models of virtue in broader classical education language (as part of the ethical framework) but do not consistently foreground the exact phrasing used in the formal classical rubric for faculty identity.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: virtue, character formation, mentorship, model teachers, Catholic formation, professionalism, ethics, wisdom, truth-seeking, faith and reason.
- Negative keywords present: a lack of explicit, consistent language about the “living curriculum” or explicit statements that the faculty themselves constitute the core of the curriculum, which the rubric flags as a hallmark of a fully Classical faculty identity.

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates strong virtue-formation signals and a faculty that upholds Catholic virtues, but it does not consistently foreground the exact classical rubric language (living-curriculum/faculty-as-core) in public-facing materials. This results in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL for Element 5.

Cited sources

- historical and current faculty structure, Catholic formation language, and collaborative approach with families.
- explicit statements of formation and virtue in mission/philosophy as a faculty signal.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly positions parents as partners in education, framing parental collaboration as essential to forming the whole child. The philosophy explicitly notes collaboration with each parent and formation of the whole person through joint educational work. This aligns strongly with the Classical model’s emphasis on family partnership and shared mission.
- There are public materials describing parent involvement and opportunities to participate in school life (e.g., fall festival and other community activities; communications encouraging visits and engagement). The Fall Festival and admissions materials illustrate active parental engagement and community outreach.
- The school’s public messages show a design that invites parents to be co-educators and to engage in book/learning activities (via readings, gatherings, tours). This matches the “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections” positive keyword indicators.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent cooperation, parental engagement, family catechesis, home-school partnership, community of learners, school as extension of the home, parental formation.
- Negative keywords present: minimal signals of parental disengagement or limited access; the site consistently invites parental involvement and communication, reducing negative indicators.

Why this rating

- The presence of explicit family partnership language, parental engagement, and open invitation for parental involvement aligns strongly with CLASSICAL in Element 6.

Cited sources

- Our Purpose page emphasizing collaboration with parents and formation of the whole child.
- Community and parent engagement signals (Fall Festival, admissions, and parent resources).
- Additional parent-partnership materials and information.

Overall assessment and aggregate ranking

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 5 (Faculty): Introduce and publicly foreground explicit language about teachers as the “living curriculum” and the faculty as the core culture of virtue, mentorship, and intellectual formation. A formal articulation of teachers as model virtues and as a central, pedagogical force would push Element 5 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL.
- Additionally, amplify explicit references to the Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium and Quadrivium) in public-facing materials, with a clear map of how Great Books and primary texts are embedded across grade levels. This would further strengthen cross-category alignment and reduce any residual ambiguity between formation and information-focused rhetoric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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